

In Praise of Suchness

Tattvastotra · Toh 1116 · Derge Tengyur

དཀོན་མཆོག་ཉན་ལ་བསྟོན་པ།

Toh 1116 in the Tengyur is a hymn of praise known in Sanskrit as the Tattvastotra and in Tibetan as a praise of suchness, rendered into English as "In Praise of What Is Not Mistaken" or "In Praise of Suchness." It is a devotional stotra composed by the great Indian Yogācāra master Asaṅga, offering reverent homage to the Tathāgata by meditating on the Buddha's ultimate nature — unborn, unobstructed, sky-like in its freedom from all afflictions and obscurations, and empty of any inherent self. The text belongs to the class of Indian Buddhist hymns and eulogies collected in the Tengyur, the canonical compilation of translated treatises and commentarial works, and it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Śīlendrabodhi together with the renowned Tibetan editor-translator Yeshé Dé. As a stotra, it combines philosophical insight into the nature of buddhahood with the devotional register of verse praise, reflecting Asaṅga's characteristic synthesis of Yogācāra thought and reverential contemplation.

In Praise of What Is Not Mistaken. Composed by the Master Asaṅga. Complete.

Translated and revised by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Śīlendrabodhi together with the great editorial translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, and established in definitive form.

In Sanskrit: Tattvastotra. In Tibetan: In Praise of Suchness.

Homage to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form.

I bow to the Tathāgata, whose body
is utterly free of all obstruction,
devoid of colour, unborn,
and whose own nature cannot be destroyed.

I bow to the one whose ultimate nature resembles the sky —
free of both coarse and subtle afflictions,
cleared of every obscuration,
empty because no self was ever there at the first.

Having abandoned the fabrications of conceptual thought,
acting according to whatever is pleasing,
ever beholding that suchness which is the supreme treasure,

I bow to the one who has abandoned the ruin of the lower realms.

Having relinquished all conceptual thought,
a body not fashioned by wilful striving,
a body equally flavoured in saṃsāra and in peace,
I bow to the one unstained by the filth of conceptuality.

Dwelling without sleep or deep unconsciousness,
abiding free and rid of delusion,
with suchness ever unobscured,
I bow to the one who rises as wisdom through intrinsic nature.

Completing the full cycle of meditative concentrations,
generating joy in human beings,
the pleasing moon of liberation,
I bow to the one who dispels the cataract of wrong views.

Having transcended both existence and non-existence,
freed from the stain of conceptual thought,
abiding on the ground without rejection or adoption,
I bow to the one who has no partiality.

Stainless waves of water, cause of ease,
sustaining every living being without exception,
vast, boundless, and beyond all measure,
I bow to the great ocean of suchness.

Endowed with many excellent eyes fully opened,
an incomparable flavour, delightful, alighting in the mind,
dispelling the fear of aging and death,
I bow to that suchness which is nectar.

Though beings trust in their own minds,
Viṣṇu (the Pervader), the lord Maheśvara (Śiva), Brahmā, Indra,
the gods and sages find no means —
I bow to the one who obtained that method in an instant.

Stainless, of peerless worth,
fulfilling all desires through its very nature,
the goal attained through accumulation of merit,
I bow to the wish-fulfilling awakening mind (bodhicitta).

For those utterly exhausted by the wheel of cyclic existence,
a supremely pleasant abode of peace,
in full bloom with the branches of awakening as its flowers,
I bow to the wish-granting tree of peace.

Neither knowing nor not-knowing,
free of the distinction between coarse and subtle,
transcending all manner of similes,
I bow to the one that words cannot express.

Always victorious, knowing no dismay,
the knot that overcomes the power of others — having no knot,
possessing a body of non-duality beyond conceiving,
I bow to the sole hero who conquers existence.

Pervading without distinction,
burning the aggregates of things in an instant,
blazing brilliantly by an utterly fierce nature,
I bow to that suchness which is fire.

Whatever virtue I have gained from this genuine praise —
by that merit may all beings without exception be exhausted of wandering,
may sentient beings be freed from their suffering,
endowed with happiness, unobscured, and may they attain nirvāṇa.

In Praise of Suchness. Composed by the monk Śrī Kavaca of the Śākya order.
Complete.

The Indian preceptors —

Translator's Notes

- The text contains two distinct works placed in sequence. The first colophon closes the Stava on What Is Not Mistaken attributed to Asaṅga. Immediately following is a separate text, the Tattvastotra, attributed in its closing colophon to a Śākya monk named Śrī Kavaca, translated by the same team of Jinamitra, Śīlendrabadhi, and Yeshé Dé. The final line breaks off mid-sentence, indicating the passage given is incomplete.

The verse "rtsed dor med de sa mnyam gnas" is somewhat compressed; the rendering "abiding on the ground without rejection or adoption" follows the standard Madhyamaka sense of the line, though "rtsed dor" could also be read as "neither grasping nor discarding."

The phrase rendered "completing the full cycle of meditative concentrations" translates "bsam gtan tshes grangs yongs rdzogs pa," where "tshes grangs" literally means "the count of days or dates" but in context refers to the full enumeration or completion of dhyāna stages.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.